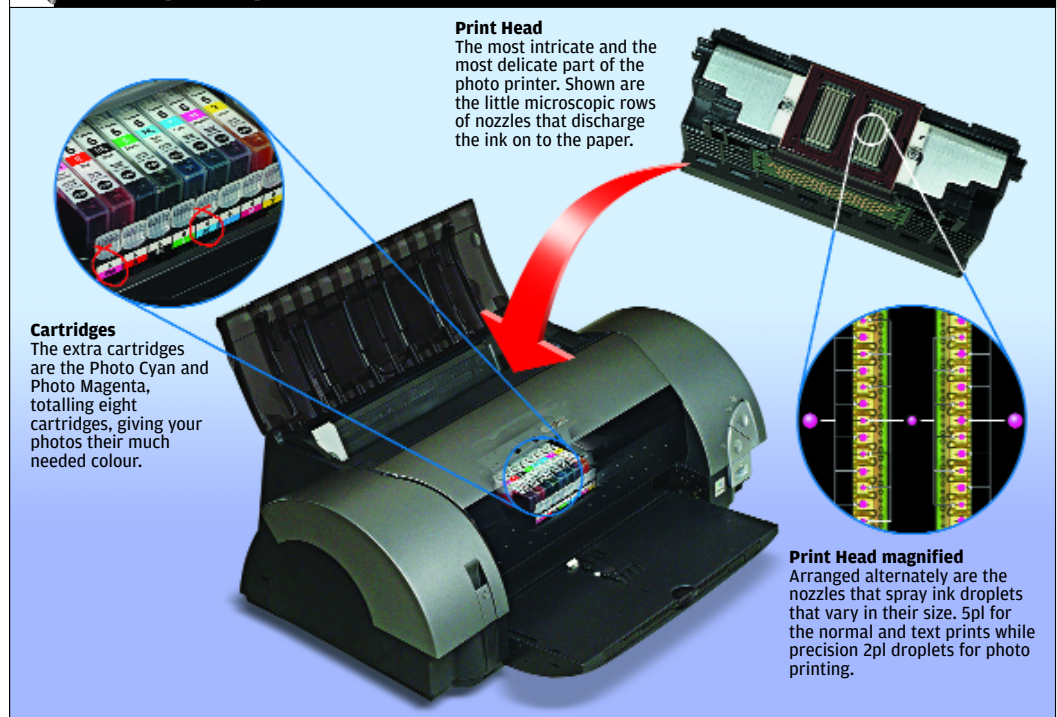




How a photo printer works



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magenta, yellow and black. This transparent sheet is actually a film made up of the coloured dyes. When a photo is printed, the print head heats up.

This print head consists of thousands of heating elements, which heat the dye on the film and cause it to vaporise and diffuse into the glossy paper. The temperature on the print head is precision controlled for each heating element, and accordingly, the dye is vaporised on the paper.

This is what results in the varied hues and colour tones. This technology has a definite advantage over ink-jet photo printing—the colours diffuse on to the paper, it does away with the thin film-like effect that occurs with an ink-based printer. Photos printed with these printers also have a longer life span since the colour has permeated into the paper—making the photo less vulnerable to fading and distortion.

What do you really need?

Before you buy a photo printer, first consider some important factors:

- ❑ Think about your usage pattern. If you need mostly text prints, and printing photos is just a new fad as far as you are concerned, you will be better off with a good quality inkjet printer, which would be more than sufficient for your needs. When you need a quality print, just go to your nearest digital photo shop and get one.
- ❑ Plan your budget: look at the costs of consumables and try making a rough calculation of your expenses.
- ❑ Decide on the technology you want to use. Do you want the absolute best, or can you compromise a little on the quality as long as you get a photo printer?

Photo printers are available in all shapes and sizes, are based on different technologies, and you have a range of manufacturers to choose from. When it comes to buying a photo printer, it can become pretty confusing to choose one. We present you with a few buying tips:

- ❑ Give speed a consideration. If two photo printers, based on the same technology and offering the same quality prints are compared, and one printer offers faster printouts, it makes more sense buying that one, even if it costs a bit more.
- ❑ Check for the various available printing options. Can you print borderless prints? Can the printer print 4 x 6 prints as well as A4 prints? Does the paper tray support various sizes of paper? Also check if the printer supports dual trays, which will reduce the hassle of changing paper types for documents and photos.
- ❑ Is portability your concern? Opt for a printer that makes for less hassle and more usability. You should be able to get a printout without messing about too much with the controls. However, be ready to spend a little more for a portable printer.
- ❑ Check if the printer supports memory cards and printing directly off a digital camera. Some photo printers are infrared-equipped, so you can directly print off mobile devices such as camera phones and PDAs. Of course, these devices do not yet support really high-quality images, but that may change soon.
- ❑ Usability features on a photo printer should include one-touch printing. This is not a feature you absolutely need, but comes in handy in situations where you just want to print without fiddling with the settings.

Photos printed using the thermal-dye technology have a longer life span, and are less vulnerable to fading and distortion